

Word family: **essay / essays / essayist / essayistic**

Base word: essay

Plural: essays

Related forms: essayist, essayistic

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / rare-literary verb (較少見、文學性的動詞)

Your sentence:

> “Most of the books I usually read are novels or personal **essays**...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **essay** means a **relatively short piece of non-fiction writing in which an author explores, reflects on, or discusses a subject**, especially from a personal, analytical, or literary perspective.

In **personal essay**, the writer often uses personal experiences, memories, observations, or reflections to explore a wider idea.

繁體中文： **散文；隨筆；以較短篇幅探討、反思或討論某個主題的非小說文章**

中文翻譯：

> “Most of the books I usually read are novels or personal **essays**...”

「我平時讀的大多是小說或者個人**隨筆 / 散文**.....」

Here:

personal essay = 作者以自己的經歷、感受或觀察為出發點，進一步反思某個主題的非小說文章

1. **essay = short piece of writing discussing a subject (文章) — 論說文；短文；散文**

This is the broad central meaning.

Meaning: A relatively short piece of writing that discusses, explains, analyzes, or reflects on a particular subject.

Practice 1

> “She wrote an **essay** about memory and identity.”

「她寫了一篇關於記憶與身分認同的**文章 / 論說文**。」

Practice 2

> “The book contains a collection of **essays** on modern life.”

「這本書收錄了一系列探討現代生活的**散文 / 文章**。」

essay = 以較完整、連貫的方式討論或探索一個主題的短篇非小說文章

Common:

- * write an essay
- * collection of essays
- * critical essay
- * literary essay
- * reflective essay

2. **essay** = academic/school assignment (學業) — 論文；作文；課業文章

In school and university contexts, an **essay** is a structured piece of writing produced as an assignment or examination response.

Practice 3

> “We have to write a 2,000-word **essay**.”

「我們要寫一篇二千字的**論文 / 文章**。」

Practice 4

> “Her history **essay** was due on Friday.”

「她的歷史科**論文 / 作文**星期五到期。」

essay = 學生為課業、評核或考試而撰寫的、有結構地分析或討論某題目的文章

Common:

- * essay question
- * essay assignment
- * essay topic
- * essay structure
- * essay writing

This is extremely common.

However, semantically it is still the same underlying idea as Meaning 1:

> **a structured piece of prose discussing a topic**

So I would display it separately for learner usefulness but **merge it for strict core counting**.

3. **personal essay = reflective literary non-fiction (文學) — 個人隨筆 ; 個人散文**

This is the exact subtype used in your passage.

Practice 5 — Original

> “I usually read novels or personal **essays**.”

「我平時通常讀小說或個人**隨筆**。」

Practice 6

> “The writer published a personal **essay** about growing older.”

「那位作家發表了一篇關於年齡增長的個人**散文 / 隨筆**。」

Practice 7

> “Her **essay** begins with a childhood memory.”

「她的**隨筆**以一段童年回憶作開頭。」

personal essay = 以作者自身經歷、感受、記憶或觀察來探索更廣泛主題的非小說散文

This is not a separate dictionary meaning from #1, but it is an important literary subtype.

4. **essay = written answer in an examination (考試) — 論述題答案 ; 作文**

In examination contexts, **essay** can refer to an extended written answer.

Practice 8

> “The exam includes two **essay** questions.”

「考試包括兩條**論述題**。」

Practice 9

> “You have forty minutes to complete the **essay**.”

「你有四十分鐘完成這篇**論述文章 / 作文**。」

Again, this belongs to the academic-writing branch rather than being a genuinely separate semantic core.

5. **essay** = an attempt (古典 / 文學用法) — 嘗試 ; 試圖**

Historically, **essay** can also mean an attempt or trial.

This survives most clearly in the verb **to essay**, meaning **to attempt or try**.

Practice 10

> “He ** essayed** a smile.”

「他**勉強試着**露出笑容。」

Practice 11

> “She ** essayed** a reply but stopped.”

「她**試圖**回答，但又停了下來。」

essay (verb) = attempt / try

This use is real, but it is **literary, formal, and uncommon in modern everyday English**.

For your database, I would not put it in the main learner core unless you want broader literary coverage.

Related form: **essayist**

An **essayist** is someone known for writing essays, especially literary or reflective essays.

Practice 12

> “She became known as a brilliant **essayist**.”

「她以出色的**散文家 / 隨筆作家**身分聞名。」

essayist = 經常撰寫散文、隨筆或評論文章的作家

This is a useful literary-family word.

Related form: **essayistic**

Essayistic means having the qualities or style of an essay, especially being reflective, exploratory, analytical, or discursive.

Practice 13

> “The film has an **essayistic** style.”

「這部電影具有一種**散文式 / 論述式**的風格。」

Practice 14

> “Her writing is highly **essayistic**.”

「她的寫作風格非常**散文化 / 思辨式**。」

This is an established word, but it is considerably more specialist and should be treated as lower priority.

Important distinction: **essay vs article**

essay

often:

- * explores an idea in depth
- * contains argument, reflection, or interpretation
- * may be academic or literary

article

is broader and often written for:

- * newspapers
- * magazines
- * websites
- * journals

- > an essay on identity
- > a news article

An article can be informative without being an essay.

Important distinction: **essay vs report**

essay

usually develops an argument or interpretation.

report

usually presents:

- * findings
- * facts
- * observations
- * results
- * recommendations

A report is normally more structured and practical.

Important distinction: **essay vs paper**

In academic contexts, they overlap.

essay

often means a shorter course assignment.

paper

can mean an academic assignment but can also refer to a formal research paper prepared for publication.

- > write an essay for class

> publish a research paper

Usage varies by educational system.

Important distinction: **essay vs composition**

composition

can mean any piece of written work and is often used in language education.

essay

usually implies more developed discussion, analysis, or reflection.

> English composition

> argumentative essay

Important distinction: **essay vs dissertation/thesis**

essay

usually relatively short.

dissertation / thesis

is much longer and based on sustained academic research.

So:

> a 1,500-word essay

is completely normal.

> a 1,500-word dissertation

would normally be far too short.

Important distinction: **essay vs memoir**

This matters for **personal essay**.

personal essay

uses personal experience to explore an idea or theme, usually in a relatively short form.

memoir

is a longer autobiographical work focused on a period, theme, or set of experiences from someone's life.

A personal essay may feel memoir-like, but they are not identical genres.

Countability note

Essay is normally countable:

- > an essay
- > three essays
- > a collection of essays

You can also modify it by type:

- * academic essay
- * personal essay
- * critical essay
- * argumentative essay
- * reflective essay

Useful construction: **essay on/about something** — 關於.....的文章

Practice 15

> “He wrote an **essay on** modern architecture.”

「他寫了一篇關於現代建築的**文章**。」

Both are possible:

- > essay on something
- > essay about something

On often sounds slightly more academic/formal.

Useful compound: **essay question** — 論述題

Practice 16

> “Choose one of the three **essay questions**.”

「三條**論述題**中選一條作答。」

This is an important educational compound, not a separate base-word meaning.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family is fairly small:

* **essay**

* **essays**

* **essayist**

* **essayistic**

There is also the verb **essay** = attempt, but it is literary and low-frequency in contemporary everyday English.

The central modern noun is semantically quite unified: school essays, literary essays, personal essays, and critical essays are all versions of the same basic concept—**a structured prose piece exploring or discussing a subject**. Under the curation rules, different genres or settings should therefore not be turned into separate meanings merely because their purpose or audience differs.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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essay — general writing	一篇以較完整方式分析、討論或反思某個主題的短篇文章
essay — academic assignment	為學校、課程、評核或考試而撰寫的結構化論述文章；屬於 general essay 義
personal essay	以作者自身經歷、感受或觀察探索某個較廣泛主題的個人隨筆 / 散文
essay question	要求考生以較長篇幅分析、解釋或論證的論述題
essay — verb, literary	嘗試、試圖做某事；現代日常英語較少見
essayist	散文家；隨筆作家
essayistic	具有散文式、思辨式或論述式風格的

For your original sentence

> “Most of the books I usually read are novels or personal **essays**...”

The exact meaning is:

personal essays = 以作者個人經歷、觀察和感受為材料，進一步反思人生、社會或其他主題的非小說散文

So:

> **novels or personal essays**

= **小說或個人隨筆 / 個人散文**

For your database, **essay** is actually a fairly low-polysemy word compared with the others we have been mapping.

I would count just **2** genuinely distinct meanings:

1. **noun** — a structured piece of prose discussing or exploring a subject
2. **verb** — to attempt/try, literary and low-priority

I would **not** split academic essay, personal essay, critical essay, examination essay, and literary essay into separate core meanings. They are different genres or uses of the same underlying writing concept.